17 February 1984 and had conducted a ‘ground recce’ of the Golden Temple with some members of the Indian special forces (SFF). The officer’s advice was that ‘a military operation should only be put into effect as a last resort, when all attempts at negotiation had failed. It recommended including in any operation an element of surprise and the use of helicopter-borne forces, in the interests of reducing casualties and bringing about a swift resolution.’ [4]

Quoting the Heywood Report, Hague mentioned that ‘with a view to reducing casualties, the UK military advisor recommended assaulting all objectives simultaneously, thereby assuring surprise and momentum. The advice given to the Indian authorities identified (the use of) sufficient helicopters, and the capability to insert troops by helicopter as critical requirement(s) for this approach.’

Further, ‘The UK advice also focused on command and control arrangements, and night time coordination of paramilitary with Indian special group forces.’ The report mentioned that there were ‘significant differences’ between the plan proposed by the SAS and the eventual operation that was mounted (Blue Star). The UK’s assistance was purely ‘advisory’ and given months beforehand. It noted, ‘Operation Bluestar was a ground assault, without an element of surprise, and without a helicopter-borne element.’

The British cabinet secretary’s report concluded that the SAS officer’s advice had limited impact on Operation Blue Star. It also tried to underline the absence of British involvement in the eventual Operation Blue Star by publishing correspondence between Indira Gandhi and Margaret Thatcher dated 14 June and 29 June 2014, which did not make any such mention. An analysis conducted by the British military for Heywood also concluded that the eventual operation was carried out by the Indian army in June 1984 in a wholly different way from what was suggested by the SAS.

Furore in British parliament

When details of this inquiry were revealed in the House of Commons, there were shouts of ‘shame’ from the ruling Conservative Party benches too. John McDonnell, the Labour MP